



Mignola didn't have complete control over the film.

make a film of this." When I met Del Toro, I realised if anybody was going to make a *Hellboy* film, he was the guy to do it, but it was always such an uphill battle that I never thought it was gonna happen.

Was it hard seeing *Hellboy* changed for the big screen?
I'm not someone who says something needs to be like the source material. In fact, during my first meeting with Del Toro, I told him: "I'd love for the film to be true to the spirit of the character, but you turn it into whatever you want to." I actually had an idea for an easier *Hellboy* movie; Del Toro was the one who wanted the film to be faithful to the comic!

But there are fairly big changes from the comic...
Yeah. Del Toro thought the love interest was necessary, and there were scenes in there he'd wanted to do for years, which *Hellboy* became a vehicle for. But that's great! I wanted a filmmaker with his own agenda, because then you get an interesting film. And the process was good; we mostly saw eye-to-eye. But the five per cent where we didn't was hard, because it was his film, and he had the final say on certain things with my character. To survive that, I had to remember the comic's the comic, the film's the film, and that I was working with a guy I really liked on *his* movie, not working on my movie. It's a similar experience with the sequel, but increasingly the film is Del Toro's, especially as the story veers further from the comic.

Why is the sequel's direction towards the folklore side of the comics?
That was a conscious decision we both made, because that element was missing from the first film, which instead had the Lovecraft-meets-pulp-magazine-mad-scientist stuff. If you look at the two films together, you see the range of *Hellboy*.

How hard a pitch was *Hellboy 2*?
It was easier when *Pan's Labyrinth* came out, which I'd not seen when we made up the story. Because we were pitching a story where Hellboy fights fairies and elves, we knew we'd have to jump in at some point and say: "But it's not what you think! It's going to be dark and scary!" After *Pan's Labyrinth*, this was easier for studios to understand. People usually think of cute fairies in a garden, but in *Hellboy* you'll see a nasty kind of fairy, and that's not what an audience is used to.

What prompted the *Hellboy* animated features?
Del Toro talked about an animation, and Revolution Studios set it up. I wasn't the driving force behind it, but when I heard they wanted to do animation, I recommended *Hellboy* fan Ted Stone, who'd been at Disney and had recently become available. For an animation to happen, someone needed to be involved who understood the comic, because clearly Del Toro wasn't going to have time to devote to it, and I'm not an animator. We needed someone who knew animation and who knew *Hellboy*.

Are you happy with the visual style, since it's very different to your own?
I think the fans feel otherwise, but I was very happy the studio didn't want to use my style. When things are in my style, I sit there going: "Oh, they don't understand it, they're not doing it right." I just see the mistakes. And the style is another thing that distances it from the comics, making the animation an alternate version of *Hellboy*. It remains faithful, though, and the animation is closer to the stories I did than the movies.

Is it difficult to no longer be totally in control of *Hellboy*?
On one hand, it's great, because I'm exposing *Hellboy* to a much wider audience, and more people will discover the comic. The flip side is that most will never see what I do, but at least I got something out to the world! And as someone who erases ten lines for every one he draws, not drawing for a while was actually a kind of relief. But you start to miss getting your hands into everything, and there's a danger of spending so much time overseeing different things that you can't focus on any one thing.

What is the future for Mike Mignola?
I've been writing these past couple of years, and I'm getting that itch to draw and write some material myself, because there's so much interesting stuff you can do when you're doing everything yourself. I want to do something that's more experimental, where I'm playing with the art form. I've also just co-wrote and illustrated *Baltimore: Or, The Steadfast Tin Soldier And The Vampire* with Chris Golden, and that worked out well. A few other things I've made up (which could be 200-page graphic novels) I'm not in a position to do, but the idea of writing them up, handing them over to Chris, and collaborating on another novel that I'd illustrate – that's something we've talked about doing.

And *Hellboy*?
Hellboy has a future. I've plotted it to the end of the series – or what could be the end – so my goal is to get to do the whole story. Hopefully, I can get Duncan Fegredo [*Hellboy*'s new main artist] to stick around to the bitter end! I'm really happy with the collaboration, and I just want to finish the story!

That'd be great to see; few long-running series have a coherent beginning, middle and end. That's one of the problems of mainstream comics: they have the illusion of change, but they're properties of giant companies. They'll never let you keep Superman dead! But because I control *Hellboy* – at least the comic-book version – I can make definite changes with the character, and they're happening right now. It's very strange: after ten years fumbling around in the *Hellboy* world, it's now set on a certain course, and I'm turning corners where there's no going back, which is exciting, but daunting.

The weird thing will be if Del Toro gets to do a third *Hellboy* film, which would probably be the end of that film cycle. He'd be doing the end of *Hellboy* a decade before I get to. One thing I've got to be real careful of is that I don't tell Del Toro how I plan to end the comic, because I sure as hell don't want him to put it on film first!

INFORMATION BITES

Mike Mignola

// Born in the Sixties, in sunny California, Mike Mignola began his comics career due to wanting to "draw monsters for a living".

// Mike's early work largely included inking, and he worked on Marvel Comics' *Daredevil*, *Rocket Raccoon* and *Alpha Flight*.

// Mike's first breakthrough in the industry was arguably his work on *Batman*, which included covers, pencilling work and scripting.

// *Gotham By Gaslight*, to which Mike contributed, sees an 1880s Batman battling Jack The Ripper, and is now considered the first *Elseworlds* story.

// Hellboy first appeared in 1994, published by Dark Horse, drawing on Mike's many and varied interests.

// One-shot *ZombieWorld* was initially made up by Mike "as a joke on the phone" when talking to his editor.

// Many *Hellboy* trade paperbacks include additional or edited pages, discussions of content by the author, and other such extras.

// Although previously illustrating the bulk of *Hellboy*, Mike passed primary art duties to Duncan Fegredo in 2007.

// When *Hellboy* movie rights were optioned, Mike created a new character, in case the film was horrendous.

Along with working on the *Hellboy* movie, Mike also worked on *Blade II* and *Bram Stoker's Dracula*.

